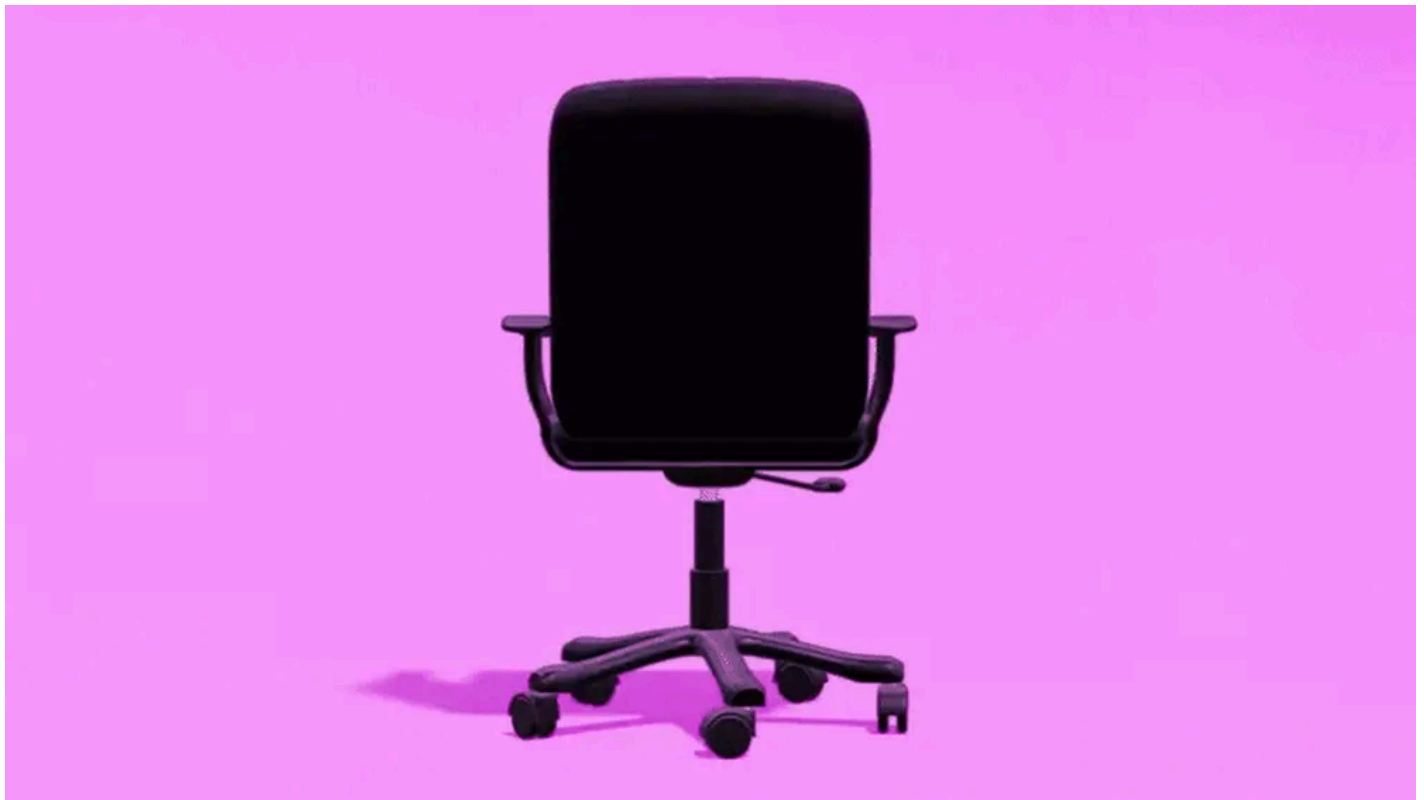


The AI boom is leaving women behind

Data shows women are less likely to hold AI jobs and more likely to be in AI-vulnerable jobs.



— Women hold about 29% of corporate leadership roles in the U.S. but only 16% of AI-focused leadership roles.

Leila Register / NBC News; Getty Images

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By Ashley Mowreader

Rapid growth in AI jobs is leaving women out of the winnings.

New data from LinkedIn shows women made up only one-quarter of new hires in AI roles in 2025 while making up half of new hires in non-AI jobs. In addition, women working in AI-focused positions are less likely than men to be in high-earning or leadership-level roles.

The trend is a symptom of science, technology, engineering and math talent pipelines for women and a lack of trust for AI tools and the benefits they can provide to women, experts told NBC News.

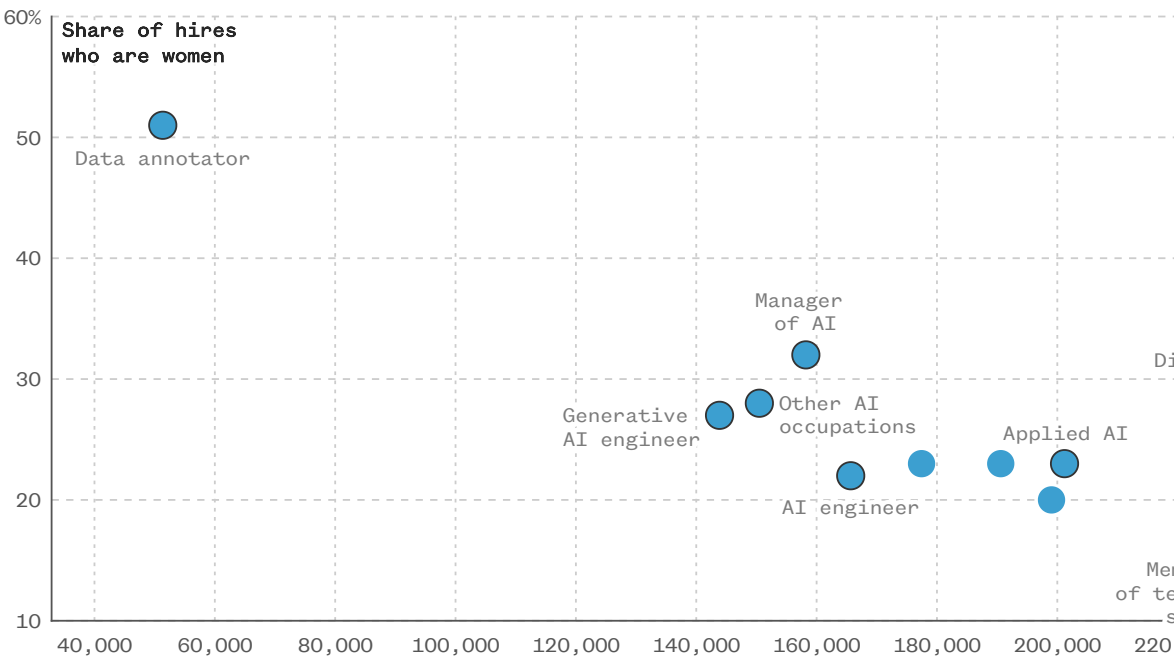
“If women remain underrepresented as the field of AI grows, there’s a real risk that they miss out not only on the jobs of today, but on the experience and the advancement opportunities that will position them for leadership in the future,” said Maria Flynn, CEO of Jobs for the Future, a nonprofit focused on education and workforce development.

Business leaders have declared AI jobs to be “[jobs of the future](#),” and growth in artificial intelligence businesses has [buoyed the U.S. economy](#) for months, creating jobs in fields from [construction](#) to product development. AI jobs have grown at twice the rate of other roles since 2023 and with higher average salaries, according to LinkedIn’s data – but these roles are mostly going to men.

Women make up a disproportionately small fraction of all C-suite executives in the U.S. but are even less represented at AI firms, which LinkedIn defines as either known AI companies or a company with at least 10% of workers in AI roles. Women hold about 29% of corporate leadership roles in the U.S. but only 23% of AI firms’ leadership roles and 16% of AI-focused leadership roles. In nonexecutive roles, women make up 50% of non-AI companies but only 39% of jobs in AI firms.

Fewer women hold high-earning AI jobs

The AI job with the greatest gender parity is data annotator, which is 51% female but pays just over \$50,000.



Notes: Data reflects U.S. hiring and median pay data as of 2026.
Source: LinkedIn

The AI-attached role with the largest share of women represented, data annotators, is also the job with the lowest pay. Data annotator jobs are hourly-paid, project-based and often remote. These features can be attractive to women balancing work with caregiving responsibilities, according to LinkedIn’s analysis.

In comparison, heads of AI and “members of technical staff” roles are among the highest-paid AI jobs. Women make up less than a quarter of hires in both categories.

“Unfortunately, it reflects some of the trends that we have seen around women in STEM occupations broadly for many years,” Flynn said. “Even though AI is bringing new opportunities and rapidly advancing technologies to the workplace, when it comes to career preparation and career pathways, we need to be thinking about how we really make them accessible and appealing to both men and women.”

One of the contributing factors to women’s lag in AI roles could be a distrust in the tools or the firms that create and manage them.

In 2024, there was an [11-percentage-point gender gap](#) between men and women in AI chatbot use, according to a study by Pew Research Center. That gap has narrowed since, with 47% of women saying they use AI chatbots in 2026, compared with just over half of men.

However, men are more likely to say that they are regular users of AI and that they engage with chatbots for work, while women are only more likely to use chatbots for emotional support or advice.

“Having women in these roles as AI is being shaped is also critically important,” Flynn said. “It’s important in terms of the skills and the points of view and the knowledge that women need to bring to the table in the development and deployment of technology.”

Gender differences in AI chatbot use

Men are more likely to say they use chatbots for search or work, compared with women.

	Men	Women
To search for information	45%	39%
For tasks at work	40%	35%
For fun or entertainment	28%	22%
To create or edit images, videos	24%	23%
To get medical advice	21%	19%

To get diet or fitness information	20%	19%
To get news	15%	12%
For emotional support or advice	8%	11%
For companionship	4%	4%

Source: [February 2026 survey by Pew Research Center](#)

Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

Pew's study also found that women had some anxieties about AI's rapid development; women were more likely to believe that AI will have a negative impact on themselves and society over the next 20 years and that AI is advancing too quickly.

"There's a very real consideration that women might be making, which is, well, is this technology going to make my job better and more productive and result in wage gains for me, or is it going to be used to replace me?" said Sarah Steinberg, head of global public policy partnerships at LinkedIn.

Previous LinkedIn data found that approximately 1 in 3 women globally work in jobs that are going to be disrupted by AI, while that number is closer to 1 in 4 for men, Steinberg said. An April report from the National Partnership for Women and Families found that [6 million women could see their jobs affected by artificial intelligence](#) in roles such as administrative support, clerical work or customer service.

Women are historically underrepresented in STEM roles, and while AI jobs are no exception, these roles are a unique combination of high-paying and high-growth that makes it even more important to consider gender equality, Steinberg said.

Hiring managers and businesses should also consider the ways a lack of gender parity in talent pipelines can hinder future economic growth, Steinberg said.

"This is a competitiveness and business risk issue," Steinberg said. "If you're leaving half of the population on the table, then you're not going to be able to get the workforce that you need."

To close the divide, Steinberg and Flynn recommended that businesses consider using skills-based hiring practices, offering flexible or remote work opportunities, and implementing training and professional development opportunities.

"In order for us to get to the gender equality that we would like to see, it's going to require all parties to be intentional about this and to think about how to kind of embed these design elements from the beginning," Flynn said.

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